



FEATURE REFERENCE

CarouseLabs — Complete Feature Documentation

A full reference of every feature in the CarouseLabs AI content-creation product: generation flows, the AI pipeline, templates, platforms, editing controls, plans & credits, and account tools. Compiled directly from the current codebase.

PRODUCT

CarouseLabs Content Studio

SCOPE

Content-creation product only

PREPARED

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1 Overview

CarouselLabs is an AI content-creation studio that turns a topic — or nothing at all — into a ready-to-post caption, on-brand image, or full multi-slide carousel, tailored to any of 8 supported platforms. It's built for founders, creators, and marketers who want consistent, high-quality social content without a design tool, a writer, or hours per post.

Every generation runs through the same underlying pipeline regardless of entry point: a caption is drafted first, and — for image or carousel formats — a 3-stage AI process plans the layout, writes a visual brief, and renders the final image. The product is built around two symmetric entry points (own idea vs. AI-suggested idea, see Section 2), three output formats (Section 3), and a personalization layer (Section 10) that shapes every generation to the user's profile, industry, and voice.

2 Two Ways to Create

Every session starts from one of two entry points, both landing on the same breakdown → format-picker → generation flow.

2.1 Work on Own Idea

- **Title** — up to 15 words, enforced client- and server-side.
- **Notes** — "Tell us more about your idea," up to 650 words.
- Claude (`claude-sonnet-4-5`) runs a **Research Expansion** pass that turns the title + notes into a full breakdown: an 800–2,000 word knowledge document, a refined hook, key talking points, and a strong ending line — generated immediately, with no separate "breakdown" step.

2.2 Trending / AI-Suggested Ideas

- The dashboard generates **10 ideas per request, on demand** — not a fixed daily batch. Mix: 3 Latest News + 3 Trending Topic + 3 Industry Topic + 1 Random-but-relevant.
- "Latest News" ideas are grounded in real headlines from NewsAPI.org (last 48 hours) when available; otherwise Claude falls back to its own knowledge, labeled "[Trending]".
- Rate-limited to **10 generations per hour** per user.
- "Load More" fetches 10 more, deduplicated against already-seen hooks, capped at **30 ideas per session**.
- "Work on Own Idea" is always pinned first in the feed, above the AI-suggested ideas.
- Any idea can be **duplicated** into a fresh session (clones the idea + latest breakdown) without disturbing the original.

3 Output Formats

Every idea — own or suggested — can become any of three outputs.

FORMAT	WHAT YOU GET	CREDIT COST
Caption Only	A scroll-stopping caption, written for the selected platform, ready to post	5 credits
Image + Caption	A caption plus one AI-generated visual (4:5 portrait or 1:1 square)	15 credits
Caption + Slides (Carousel)	A caption plus a full 7–8 slide carousel, each slide individually generated	40 credits

Caption Only and Image + Caption are available on every plan, including Free. The Carousel format requires a paid plan (Pro or Growth).

4 The 3-Stage AI Pipeline

Image and carousel generation don't rely on a single prompt — they run through a 3-stage pipeline that mirrors a real design process.

- **Stage 1 — Plan the layout.** GPT-4o decides how the content should be visually organized: for a single image, a layout approach (e.g. "Hero + Infographic"); for a carousel, the slide count, order, and section roles (Hook → Problem → Solution → CTA, etc).
- **Stage 2 — Write the visual brief.** GPT-4o (primary) turns that structural decision, plus the caption and breakdown, into the actual image-generation prompt — a headline and detailed visual brief per slide for carousels. Falls back automatically to Claude Sonnet 4.5 on refusal or API error.
- **Stage 3 — Generate the image.** OpenAI's `gpt-image-2` renders the final visual — `images.generate` normally, or `images.edit` when a style reference is attached. Carousel slides are generated sequentially (not in parallel) to stay within rate limits.

This pipeline runs for every idea — own or AI-suggested — not just the Own Idea flow.

5 Structure Templates

Proven content frameworks keep output from feeling formulaic, across all three formats.

LIBRARY	TEMPLATES	CATEGORIES
Carousel structures	30	12
Image structures	21	7
Caption structures	36	9
Total	87	—

For any format, the user can let the AI auto-select the best structure, describe their own, or hand-pick a template. Carousels additionally support **"Follow My Reference Image's Structure"** — matching the slide layout and flow of an uploaded example, independent of its visual style.

6 Platform-Specific Optimization

Captions are tailored to the selected platform's tone, length, and conventions — not one-size-fits-all.

PLATFORM	CHARACTER LIMIT	STYLE
 LinkedIn	3,000	Professional tone, hashtags at the end
 Instagram	2,200	Casual and visual, hashtag-heavy (15–30 tags)
 X (Twitter)	280	Short and punchy, thread-friendly for longer ideas
 Facebook	5,000	Conversational tone, longer form okay, link-friendly
 Threads	500	Casual and relaxed, Twitter-like but more personal
 TikTok	2,200	Very casual, trend-aware, emoji-heavy, hook in the first line
 YouTube	5,000	Video description style, timestamps and SEO keywords
 Pinterest	500	Short, SEO-keyword-heavy, description style, searchable phrases

Only LinkedIn currently supports one-click direct posting from CarouseLabs — see Section 12. The other 7 platforms shape the generated caption's tone and length, but publishing is manual (copy → paste).

7 Reference Image Style Matching

Upload one example post, and every generated visual matches its look — without copying it.

- The reference image is sent to vision-capable models at up to three separate pipeline stages, each paired with an explicit instruction to extract **style only** — typography, color relationships, layout philosophy — and never copy layout, composition, icons, text, logos, or any identifiable visual element.
- A **"reference-only" structure mode** lets a reference image drive composition/reading order specifically, independent of color or typography.
- At the final image-generation stage, the reference is passed again to `gpt-image-2` via `images.edit`, reinforcing "keep the tone and accents consistent; don't copy the content."
- Uploaded references are client-side compressed (max 1024px, JPEG quality 0.8) before upload, to stay under payload limits.

8 Regeneration & Editing Controls

Every generation surface (caption, image, carousel) shares a common set of fine-grained controls.

- **Tone Selector** — 5 tones (Analytical, Candid, Playful, Authoritative, Story-driven) for the initial caption pass.
- **Custom Instructions** — an optional free-text box (up to 1,000 characters) attached to any regeneration, e.g. "make it shorter," "add more stats."
- **Apply My Voice Guidelines** — a checkbox that folds the user's saved writing-style guidelines into the regeneration (only shown if guidelines exist).
- **Hook Variations** — AI-suggested alternate opening lines; clicking one swaps the caption's hook.
- **Hashtag Chips** — suggested hashtags, click to append to the caption.
- **Version History** — up to 2 prior versions kept and individually restorable, for both captions and carousels.
- **Image aspect ratio** — 4:5 Portrait or 1:1 Square, remembered across sessions.
- **Per-slide regeneration** — each carousel slide can be regenerated independently, with its own custom-instructions box, for 8 credits.
- **Download All as PDF** — exports a full carousel as a print-ready PDF, one slide per page at native resolution.

Regeneration is capped at 2 uses per idea, per session — applied consistently across caption, image, and carousel regeneration.

9 History, Pinned & Drafts

History

- Search by keyword; filter by Caption / Image / Carousel
- Idea-category tag (News / Trending / Industry / Random)
- "Draft saved" badge when a session has unpublished work
- Per-card: pin, duplicate, resume, or delete
- "Continue" resumes exactly where a session left off

Pinned ("Content Wishlist")

- Ideas saved at the **idea** level, before generation starts
- No session is created just by pinning
- Searchable, individually removable

Drafts

There's no separate drafts page — every generated post is saved with a **DRAFT** status by default, surfaced back in History via the "Draft saved" badge. A "Save Draft" button appears in every editor, and caption edits are additionally auto-saved in the background as a safety net.

10 Onboarding & Personalization

A one-time profile (editable anytime in Settings → Profile) personalizes every idea and caption generated.

- **Identity** — one role: Founder/Entrepreneur, Content Creator, Freelancer, Operator/Manager, Consultant, Executive/CXO, or Other.
- **Industry & Niche** — searchable industry, plus a free-text niche description (up to 500 words).
- **Content Topics** — 3 to 7 topic tags, from suggestions or free text.
- **Target Audience** — audience role, seniority (6 levels), audience industry, and core problem being solved (up to 200 words).
- **Content Goals** — multi-select from 5 goals (brand-building, lead gen, audience growth, thought leadership, education), with one marked primary.
- **Tone & Voice** — multi-select from 5 base tones (Professional, Conversational, Inspirational, Educational, Bold).

This profile feeds directly into idea generation (topic selection, news-query targeting) and every caption prompt (audience, goals, tone) — it's functional personalization, not a cosmetic form.

11 Voice Presets & Voice Guidelines

- **Voice Presets** — named, reusable combinations of the 5 base tones. Up to **5 presets** can be saved, added, edited, or deleted.
- **Voice Guidelines** — a single free-form text block (soft target of ~1,000 words) where a user pastes tone/phrasing instructions or example best-performing posts, for the AI to match their exact writing style. Applied via the "Apply my voice guidelines" checkbox at generation time.

12 LinkedIn Direct Posting

- Connect a LinkedIn account once via OAuth (Settings → Account); the connection status, name, and any expiry are shown there.
- "Post to LinkedIn" is available on every generation surface — caption-only, single image, and carousel — and posts the caption plus up to 8 images directly to the connected account.
- On success, a confirmation links straight to the live post.
- This is currently the **only** platform with direct publishing; all others are copy-paste.

13 Plans & Credits

PLAN	PRICE	CREDITS	INCLUDES
Free	\$0	1 lifetime post	Caption Only & Image + Caption, basic idea generation. No carousel, no LinkedIn posting, no voice guidelines.
Pro ★ Most Popular	\$24.99/mo	1,000 / mo	Everything in Free, plus: carousels, LinkedIn posting, reference-image style matching, voice guidelines & presets, daily trending ideas, all regeneration types, priority support.
Growth	\$45.99/mo	2,000 / mo	Everything in Pro, with a higher monthly credit ceiling for agencies and power users. (No team/multi-seat features exist — this is a credit-volume tier, not collaboration.)

Credit costs

ACTION	COST
Caption Only (first generation)	5 credits
Image + Caption (first generation)	15 credits
Carousel (first generation)	40 credits
Regenerate caption	1 credit
Regenerate image	8 credits
Regenerate a single carousel slide	8 credits

Credit top-ups

Paid-plan users can buy extra credits anytime: **\$2 per 100 credits**, in multiples of 100 (min 100 / max 5,000 per purchase). Top-up credits expire 2 months after purchase and are only spent after the monthly allowance runs out. Checkout runs through a Lemon Squeezy overlay; plan changes and cancellations route through the same billing portal to avoid double charges.

14 Account & Billing

- **Billing tab** — current plan, renewal/cancellation date, a credits-remaining progress bar (with a low-credit warning at ≤ 100 left), the top-up widget, upgrade/manage actions, and a full plan-comparison grid.
- **Account tab** — account email and plan badge, LinkedIn connect/disconnect, and **Export My Data** — a one-click JSON download of every idea and post ever generated.
- Upgrading Pro → Growth is scheduled for the next renewal (no immediate charge); all other plan and cancellation changes go through the Lemon Squeezy customer portal.

15 Admin Tools

An internal console, visible only to admin accounts, for operating the content product.

- **Overview dashboard** — user counts by plan, total posts/carousels/images generated, credits used, and estimated API cost; quick actions to grant credits or change a user's plan by email.
- **User management** — searchable table plus per-user detail pages, bulk plan/suspend actions.
- **Credit administration, all-user post browsing**, and a **subscriptions overview** with CSV export.

- **Analytics** — usage charts and cohort retention.
 - **Audit log** of every admin action, and a **broadcast composer** for sending email announcements to users.
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Additional Features

- **Transactional email system** (via Resend) — welcome, onboarding-complete, first-post celebration, upgrade confirmation, low/exhausted credits, top-up receipt, monthly reset, renewal reminder, and cancellation confirmation.
- **Contact form** — routes to support@carouselabs.com, rate-limited to 3 messages/hour per sender.
- **Data export** — full account export as JSON (see Section 14).
- **PDF export** — full carousel export as a print-ready PDF (see Section 8).
- **Loading mini-game** — a short "stop the needle" timing game shown while content generates, so the wait doesn't feel idle; a rare win quietly notifies the team to follow up with the player.